

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Satavahanas and the Deccan - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Satavahanas and the Deccan - Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: exactly 32 original hard MCQs precede the verified PYQ block; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation repeats eight times; 128 unique option explanations and 32 unique examiner traps are separately identifiable. Four verified/routed PYQs preserve wording and key-status discipline. Six original Mains questions are independently isolated: 2 x 10 marks (≤150 words), 2 x 15 marks and 2 x 20 marks (each ≤250 words).

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Exactly 32 original questions appear before the PYQ block. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D eight times. Each question has four separately identifiable, unique option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Q1

Which formulation best places the Satavahanas in the post-Mauryan Deccan?

- A. They built a long-lived regional polity by connecting agrarian zones, routes, chiefs, towns and religious institutions.
- B. They reproduced an unchanged Mauryan bureaucracy over the whole peninsula.
- C. They ruled only the lower Krishna delta and never the western Deccan.
- D. They were merely a merchant association without dynastic kingship.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: the dynasty joined western and eastern Deccan nodes through layered authority rather than uniform control. [Q01-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: administrative vocabulary continued, but evidence does not show an unchanged Mauryan apparatus. [Q01-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: inscriptions and coins place Satavahana power in both western and eastern Deccan regions at different times. [Q01-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: rulers, genealogies, warfare and grants establish dynastic kingship, although merchants were important partners. [Q01-D]

Examiner trap 1: Do not convert the useful 'network polity' model into either statelessness or Mauryan-style centralization.

Q2

Which source strategy is safest for Satavahana chronology?

- A. Treat the longest Puranic king-list as a complete contemporary annal.
- B. Triangulate Puranic lists with inscriptions, coins, overstrikes, archaeology and bounded literary evidence.
- C. Use coin findspots alone as exact frontiers and regnal dates.
- D. Accept later literary attributions as court records without textual criticism.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Puranic recensions preserve dynastic memory but differ in names, totals and duration. [Q02-A]
- **B:** Correct: convergence among independent source classes gives the strongest broad sequence while preserving uncertainty. [Q02-B]

- **C:** Incorrect: coins establish rulers and circulation more securely than fixed borders or complete regnal chronology. [Q02-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: literary traditions such as the Gatha Saptashati require attention to compilation and transmission. [Q02-D]

Examiner trap 2: A neat date table is a modern reconstruction; label secure anchors, broad ranges and disputed links separately.

Q3

How should the labels Andhra, Andhra-Bhritya and Satavahana be handled?

- A. They prove that every Andhra-speaking population belonged to one dynasty.
- B. Andhra-Bhritya certainly means servants of the Andhras and settles political origin.
- C. The conventional identification is useful, but the labels come from different source traditions and do not settle homeland or ethnicity.
- D. Satavahana appears only in the Puranas, while Andhra appears only in inscriptions.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: a dynastic label cannot be expanded into an ethnic census of the Deccan. [Q03-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the compound is grammatically and historically debated; one translation cannot close the issue. [Q03-B]
- **C:** Correct: Puranic Andhra terminology and inscriptional/numismatic Satavahana names overlap without becoming identical evidence. [Q03-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the distribution is reversed in broad terms-Puranas emphasize Andhra, whereas inscriptions and coins use Satavahana/Satakarni names. [Q03-D]

Examiner trap 3: Never use a Puranic dynastic label as automatic proof of language, ethnicity, original homeland or continuous territory.

Q4

Which statement about Simuka is most defensible?

- A. He securely ruled from Amaravati in 78 CE.
- B. He defeated Rudradaman and overstruck his silver coins.
- C. He is known only from a Roman trade manual.
- D. He is the conventional founder, but his absolute date, predecessor and earliest territorial base remain debated.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: neither a fixed Amaravati capital nor that exact date is securely established for Simuka. [Q04-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Gautamiputra's overstrikes concern Nahapana, while Rudradaman belonged to a later rivalry. [Q04-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: dynastic lists and inscriptional-genealogical evidence, not a Roman manual alone, anchor Simuka. [Q04-C]
- **D:** Correct: founder status belongs to the broad sequence, whereas beginnings remain one of the dynasty's least secure zones. [Q04-D]

Examiner trap 4: Simuka is a sequence anchor, not permission to invent a precise accession year, capital or all-Deccan empire.

Q5

What makes Satakarni I and Naganika central to early Satavahana history?

- A. The Naneghat inscription and portraits connect genealogy, royal sacrifice, gifts and a strategic coast-plateau pass.
- B. Their record abolishes Brahmanical ritual in favour of exclusive Buddhism.
- C. They are known chiefly from the Junagadh Sanskrit prashasti.
- D. Their matronymics prove succession through women.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Naganika's Naneghat record is a route-side display of lineage, sovereignty and major Vedic sacrifices. [Q05-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the inscription foregrounds Brahmanical ritual even though later Satavahana patronage was plural. [Q05-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Junagadh is Rudradaman's Western Kshatrapa record, not the early Satavahana genealogy. [Q05-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: royal women's visibility does not establish matrilineal or female-line succession. [Q05-D]

Examiner trap 5: Repeated use of the name Satakarni complicates ruler identification; always attach the ruler to the named inscription and context.

Q6

Which evidence combination best supports Gautamiputra Satakarni's western recovery?

- A. Only the Puranic total of kings.
- B. Gautami Balashri's Nashik prashasti, Gautamiputra's records and Nahapana overstrikes read together.
- C. Only ship-motif coins from the eastern coast.
- D. Only the later Gatha Saptashati tradition.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Puranic lists cannot independently demonstrate one regional military reversal. [Q06-A]
- **B:** Correct: royal claim, grant context and numismatic reuse converge on the displacement of Kshaharata power. [Q06-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: ship motifs are linked especially with later Yajna Sri issues and do not prove this western victory. [Q06-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: a literary anthology is not the controlling archive for Gautamiputra's campaigns. [Q06-D]

Examiner trap 6: Prashasti and overstrike together strengthen an event claim, but neither yields a permanent border for the whole reign.

Q7

What is the strongest inference from the Jogalthembi hoard of Nahapana coins overstruck by Gautamiputra?

- A. All Shakas were exterminated throughout India.
- B. Every overstruck coin was produced on the day of one battle.
- C. A political takeover was accompanied by revalidation and reuse of an existing silver currency stock.
- D. The Satavahanas used only silver coinage.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Kshatrapa power continued under other lines, including the Kardamakas. [Q07-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: the hoard records a numismatic process, not the calendar of a single battle. [Q07-B]
- **C:** Correct: superimposed Satavahana devices materialize authority while conserving valuable silver. [Q07-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Satavahana issues also used lead, potin and copper, with regional variation. [Q07-D]

Examiner trap 7: Overstrike evidence is excellent for succession of authority and monetary practice, but weaker for battle date, duration and total territorial extent.

Q8

How should Rudradaman's claim of twice defeating a Satakarni but sparing him because of kinship be used?

- A. As proof that the Satavahanas became permanent Kshatrapa subjects.
- B. As a neutral official record jointly issued by both dynasties.
- C. As proof that marriage ended all warfare.
- D. As rival prashasti evidence for repeated conflict coexisting with matrimonial diplomacy.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim records victory rhetoric, not a permanent constitutional relationship. [Q08-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the Junagadh inscription is Rudradaman's royal eulogy and must be read as partisan evidence. [Q08-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: kinship could moderate a political encounter without removing structural competition. [Q08-C]
- **D:** Correct: warfare and marriage were parallel instruments in a contested western Deccan frontier. [Q08-D]

Examiner trap 8: Do not identify Rudradaman's unnamed Satakarni with certainty when scholarly reconstruction remains debated.

Q9

Which statement about Vashishthiputra Pulumavi is safest?

- A. His inscriptions and coins mark a strong eastern Deccan phase while western connections and conflicts continued.
- B. He founded the dynasty before Simuka.
- C. He permanently annexed the whole Western Kshatrapa realm.
- D. He composed the Naneghat inscription of Naganika.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Pulumavi is securely placed after Gautamiputra and is visible in both Nashik context and Andhra coin evidence. [Q09-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Simuka conventionally opens the line; Pulumavi belongs to the mature second-century phase. [Q09-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Western Kshatrapa rivalry persisted and cannot be reduced to permanent Satavahana victory. [Q09-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Naganika's record belongs to the early Satakarni I context. [Q09-D]

Examiner trap 9: Eastern coin concentration indicates presence and circulation; it does not by itself prove a single capital or uniform direct rule.

Q10

Yajna Sri Satakarni's ship-motif coins most securely indicate:

- A. A documented conquest of the Roman Empire.
- B. Maritime symbolism within a later Satavahana coastal-commercial setting.

- C. The disappearance of inland caravan trade.
- D. A navy whose exact size is known from inscriptions.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Roman contact was commercial and cultural, not Satavahana imperial conquest. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: the motif is meaningful for coastal orientation and political imagery without proving thalassocracy. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: inland centres and plateau routes remained essential to exchange. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: iconography does not supply fleet numbers, naval administration or monopoly. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: A ship on a coin is an iconographic clue, not a quantified naval history.

Q11

Which statement best handles Satavahana capitals?

- A. Amaravati was the uncontested capital under every ruler.
- B. Pratishthana was irrelevant once eastern coins appeared.
- C. Pratishthana/Paithan was a major western centre, while Amaravati-Dharanikota claims require phase-specific and evidence-bounded wording.
- D. The dynasty had no political centres because its court was mobile.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Amaravati was a major Buddhist and regional centre, but permanent-capital claims exceed the evidence. [Q11-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Pratishthana remained central to western Deccan political and commercial geography. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct: a multi-centred, shifting geography fits inscriptions, coins and routes better than one timeless capital. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: mobility and multiple centres do not imply the absence of durable royal nodes. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Separate political centre, mint zone, inscription findspot, religious centre and later tradition.

Q12

In Satavahana records, an ahara is best understood as:

- A. A guild treasury.
- B. A Vedic horse sacrifice.
- C. A Buddhist congregational hall.
- D. A territorial-revenue or administrative division whose exact reach could vary.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: guild finance belongs to shreni and endowment contexts, not the term ahara. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: ashvamedha is a royal sacrifice; ahara is administrative vocabulary. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: a chaitya is a worship hall, while a vihara contains monastic residence. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: ahara indicates territorial administration without proving identical boundaries or Mauryan functions. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: Shared administrative terminology does not establish institutional identity across dynasties.

Q13

What do maharathis and mahabhojas reveal about Satavahana rule?

- A. Powerful regional chiefs could be donors, marriage partners and intermediaries within a layered polity.
- B. They were salaried clerks with identical duties in every ahara.
- C. They were Roman governors of Deccan ports.
- D. Their appearance proves that the king had no authority.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: titles, donations and alliances show incorporation of established local power. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the titles denote elite status, not a uniform civil-service grade with fixed functions. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: no Roman provincial administration existed in the Satavahana Deccan. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: delegated and negotiated authority can coexist with substantial royal military and fiscal power. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: Use 'feudatory' as cautious analytical shorthand, not as proof of a fully formed medieval feudal constitution.

Q14

What is the soundest inference from names such as Gautamiputra and Vashishthiputra?

- A. Women alone inherited the throne.
- B. Maternal gotra or lineage affiliation mattered in legitimacy and alliance within a basically patrilineal dynasty.
- C. The Satavahana state was matriarchal.
- D. Kings rejected paternal genealogy.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the known succession remained overwhelmingly male and dynastic. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: matronymics highlight maternal affiliation without reversing the broader succession system. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: prominent queens and mothers do not establish rule by women as a constitutional principle. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: maternal emphasis supplemented rather than erased paternal dynastic identity. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: Matronymic is a naming and legitimacy clue; matriliney, matrilocality and matriarchy are separate propositions requiring separate proof.

Q15

How should early Satavahana land grants and tax immunities be interpreted?

- A. They were symbolic gifts without fiscal content.
- B. They began only after the Gupta age.
- C. They mark early transfers of revenue rights and exemptions, but not an already standardized mature feudal order.
- D. They were made exclusively to maritime merchants.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: records can transfer income, access or immunities with practical consequences. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: western Deccan inscriptions preserve pre-Gupta grant and exemption vocabulary. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: the evidence supports an early institutional process while scale, uniformity and long-term effects remain debated. [Q15-C]

- **D:** Incorrect: Brahmanas and Buddhist establishments, not only merchants, received endowments and rights. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Do not jump from one early immunity clause to a complete all-India model of Indian feudalism.

Q16

Which agrarian formulation is most defensible for the Satavahana Deccan?

- A. Irrigation alone explains every town and dynasty.
- B. Agriculture remained technologically unchanged after the megalithic phase.
- C. Only plantation crops supported the state.
- D. Iron tools, paddy transplantation in suitable zones, cotton, wells/tanks and expanding settlements supported uneven regional growth.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: water control mattered, but soils, labour, crops, routes and institutions also shaped outcomes. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: archaeological and textual evidence indicates changing production and settlement intensity. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: cotton and food crops were important, but a plantation-only model is anachronistic. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: the combined formulation links technology, crops, water and settlement without claiming uniform intensification. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Agrarian expansion was regionally differentiated; do not project Krishna-Godavari wet-rice conditions over the whole plateau.

Q17

What is the best evidence-based description of shrenis in the Satavahana economy?

- A. Guild-like occupational bodies could organize production, identity and endowments, including deposits whose income supported religious institutions.
- B. They were hereditary royal armies.
- C. They eliminated household production everywhere.
- D. They were identical to modern corporations with limited liability.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: inscriptions link occupational groups and merchant bodies to donations and financial arrangements. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: military formations and craft associations were distinct institutions. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: guild visibility does not prove the disappearance of household or small-scale production. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: modern corporate law cannot be retrojected onto early historic associations. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: A donation by a guild reveals organized capacity, not the total share of guild production in the economy.

Q18

Which statement accurately describes Satavahana coinage?

- A. It consisted only of Roman gold aurei.
- B. Regional issues used lead prominently, along with potin, copper and some silver; motifs and legends varied.
- C. Every coin carried a ship and a royal portrait.
- D. Coin finds map exact administrative borders.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: imported Roman coins were external objects and not the dynasty's sole currency. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct: metal choice and iconography were diverse, with lead especially characteristic in parts of the Deccan. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: ship motifs belong to selected later issues, while many coins used other symbols and legends. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: circulation, hoarding and reuse can carry coins beyond direct political control. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: Metal, motif, legend, findspot and overstrike answer different questions; never treat them as one undifferentiated map.

Q19

How should Roman contact be incorporated into Satavahana economic history?

- A. As proof that all Deccan prosperity depended on Rome.
- B. As evidence that Roman officials governed Satavahana ports.
- C. As one component of wider inland and Indian Ocean exchange, visible in imports and coin finds but insufficient to prove universal prosperity.
- D. As irrelevant because inland trade alone existed.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: agrarian production, internal markets and non-Roman maritime links also sustained regional economies. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: trade contact does not establish foreign political administration. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: Mediterranean exchange mattered within a larger network and had uneven regional effects. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: ports, imported objects and external texts make maritime contact historically relevant. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: Roman objects may mark trade, redistribution, imitation or elite consumption; context must decide which inference is warranted.

Q20

Which route statement is most accurate?

- A. Bharukachchha, Sopara and Kalyana were continuously controlled by one Satavahana ruler.
- B. Tagara was a seaport in the lower Krishna delta.
- C. Naneghat connected only Buddhist monasteries and had no commercial role.
- D. Western ports and passes linked with Pratishthana and Tagara, while eastern routes reached the Krishna-Godavari centres under shifting political control.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: coastal and route control changed during Satavahana-Kshatrapa rivalry. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Tagara/Ter was an inland market centre connected to western routes. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the pass combined political display, movement, taxation possibilities and commercial geography. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: the route network joined coast and interior without implying permanent ownership of every node. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: A trade text names commercial nodes, not a timeless dynastic map.

Q21

Gautamiputra's claim to uphold or restore varna order should be read primarily as:

- A. Royal Brahmanical ideology that must be compared with evidence of occupational diversity and social mobility.
- B. A demographic census proving complete endogamy.
- C. A Buddhist monastic regulation.
- D. Proof that foreign groups disappeared.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: the prashasti articulates desired hierarchy and legitimacy rather than recording society transparently. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: prescriptive language cannot demonstrate universal social practice. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim belongs to royal Brahmanical self-fashioning, not a vinaya rule. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: inscriptions and names instead show interaction and assimilation of varied groups. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: Normative varna language and lived social formation are related but not identical archives.

Q22

What does the adoption of Indian names, languages, donations and kinship by Yavana or Shaka-linked persons show?

- A. Instant disappearance of all foreign identities.
- B. Selective assimilation and participation in regional institutions rather than one-way or total cultural absorption.
- C. A ban on non-Indian religious practices.
- D. Uniform legal status across the Deccan.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: identities could be layered and context-specific rather than erased. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: donor records show agency, translation and institutional participation over time. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: plural religious and social practices continued within contact zones. [Q22-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: inscriptions do not provide a single comprehensive legal code for all communities. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Avoid both extremes: permanent foreign isolation and complete, instantaneous assimilation.

Q23

What is the strongest conclusion from inscriptions naming queens, nuns, household women and occupational donors?

- A. Women controlled every guild and monastery.
- B. The society was fully egalitarian.
- C. Women and non-royal donors had visible religious and social agency, though the archive favours people able to make recorded gifts.
- D. Patriarchal constraints disappeared.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: individual donations cannot establish universal institutional control. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: differential titles and resources contradict a simple equality claim. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: epigraphy expands social history while retaining the selection bias of durable public donation. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: agency within institutions does not erase broader patriarchal structures. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: Donor visibility is evidence of participation, not a representative census of all women or workers.

Q24

Which language-literature statement is accurate?

- A. Satavahana inscriptions were normally Sanskrit in Kharoshthi.
- B. The Gatha Saptashati is a contemporary administrative code.
- C. Prakrit was absent from royal and donative records.
- D. Prakrit in Brahmi dominates inscriptions, while the Gatha Saptashati tradition is attributed to Hala but textually layered.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Prakrit-Brahmi, not Sanskrit-Kharoshthi, is the characteristic combination. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the anthology preserves literary and social themes, not an official fiscal manual. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Prakrit is central to Satavahana epigraphy and literary memory. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct: language, script and attribution are secure at different levels and must not be conflated. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: Attribution to Hala does not prove that the surviving anthology is an unchanged single-author court text.

Q25

Which formulation best captures Satavahana religious patronage?

- A. Brahmanical sacrifices and claims coexisted with substantial Buddhist cave and stupa patronage by rulers, elites and occupational donors.
- B. The state legally imposed exclusive Buddhism.
- C. Vedic sacrifice disappeared after Satakarni I.
- D. Buddhist monuments received donations only from kings.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Naneghat ritual claims and western/eastern Buddhist donations belong in the same plural landscape. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: no evidence supports an exclusive Buddhist state religion. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Brahmanical legitimacy continued in later royal ideology. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: merchants, artisans, Yavanas, women and local chiefs also appear as donors. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: Patronage can express merit, legitimacy and route society; it is not automatic proof of exclusive personal conversion.

Q26

Which site-evidence match is correct?

- A. Kanheri-Naganika's early royal genealogy.
- B. Nashik-Satavahana and Kshatrapa inscriptions; Karla/Karle and Kanheri-multi-donor cave networks on western routes.
- C. Karla/Karle-Rudradaman's Junagadh prashasti.
- D. Nashik-only Gupta-period records.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Naganika's genealogy belongs to Naneghat, not Kanheri. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: the western cave belt preserves rival rulers, merchants, monks, women and route-linked patronage. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Rudradaman's inscription is at Junagadh in Saurashtra. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Nashik's early historic inscriptions are crucial for Kshatrapa-Satavahana history. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Spellings vary-Karla/Karle and Nasik/Nashik-but site, inscription and dynasty must remain correctly paired.

Q27

How should Amaravati be used in a Satavahana answer?

- A. As proof that every sculptural phase was commissioned by one Satavahana king.
- B. As a purely political capital with no religious landscape.
- C. As a major lower Krishna Buddhist centre with a long multi-phase history, linked to Satavahana-era networks but continuing beyond the dynasty.
- D. As a Gandharan monastery in the north-west.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the mahachaitya developed over multiple phases and patronage contexts. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: its strongest evidence is religious, artistic, donative and regional, not a secure timeless capital claim. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: this formulation preserves the Satavahana connection and the site's longer chronology. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Amaravati belongs to the Andhra/lower Krishna region, not Gandhara. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: Art-historical phase, dynastic chronology and later restoration must be separated before assigning patronage.

Q28

Which source-limit pairing is correct?

- A. Prashasti-neutral census; coin-exact border; archaeology-named dynasty automatically; Purana-contemporary annal.
- B. Prashasti-useless propaganda; coin-only metal; archaeology-no chronology; literature-no historical value.
- C. All sources have identical evidentiary strengths once translated.
- D. Prashasti-claim and ideology; coin-issuer/circulation; archaeology-material context; Purana/literature-layered memory requiring corroboration.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: each pairing exaggerates what the source can directly prove. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: biased or partial sources remain valuable when questions are matched to their capacities. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: genre, date, context and transmission produce different strengths and silences. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: the matrix distinguishes direct evidence from interpretation and sets a corroboration rule. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: Source criticism is not source rejection; use each archive for the question it can actually answer.

Q29

Which account of Satavahana decline is most defensible?

- A. Regional fragmentation produced successors such as Ikshvakus, Abhiras and Chutus while trade, settlements and religious institutions continued unevenly.

- B. One Roman embargo instantly erased every Deccan town.
- C. The dynasty merged peacefully into the Kushana Empire.
- D. A single battle ended Satavahana authority everywhere on the same date.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: political succession was regionally differentiated and accompanied by institutional continuity. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: external trade change cannot alone explain all political and regional outcomes. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Kushana power did not absorb the whole Satavahana Deccan in this manner. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: coin and inscription sequences show uneven later rulers and non-synchronous endings. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: Decline of a dynasty is not identical to collapse of economy, towns, Buddhism or Deccan connectivity.

Q30

Which boundary best separates Topic 17 from the Sangam south?

- A. All peninsular trade and ports belong only to Satavahana history.
- B. Topic 17 centres the Deccan Satavahana polity; Tamilakam's Chera-Chola-Pandya society and Sangam corpus belong to Topic 18, with only route links cross-referenced.
- C. Amaravati was a Sangam capital.
- D. The Satavahanas ruled the whole deep south uniformly.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: peninsular commerce crossed political zones and must not erase Tamil polities. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: the distinction preserves separate source corpora while allowing north-south commercial linkage. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Amaravati belongs to the lower Krishna-Andhra Buddhist landscape. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: evidence does not support uniform Satavahana control over Tamilakam. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Do not import Sangam poems, tinai ecology or Tamil dynastic details into the Satavahana core answer.

Q31

Which ruler-title-site-inscription-coin combination is correctly matched?

- A. Nahapana-Satavahana-Naneghat genealogy-ship coin.
- B. Rudradaman-Kshaharata-Nashik maternal prashasti-lead coin.
- C. Gautamiputra Satakarni-Satavahana-Nashik/Gautami Balashri-Nahapana overstrikes.
- D. Yajna Sri-Kardamaka-Junagadh inscription-Roman aureus.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Nahapana was a Kshaharata Kshatrapa; Naneghat and ship issues belong elsewhere. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Rudradaman was a Kardamaka Mahakshatrapa, while the maternal prashasti praises Gautamiputra. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: ruler, dynasty, inscriptional memory and numismatic evidence align. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Yajna Sri was a Satavahana associated with selected ship-motif issues, not Junagadh or Roman aurei. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: UPSC often cross-wires one correct ruler, one correct site and one correct object from different dynasties.

Q32

Which broad chronology is best ordered from earlier to later?

- A. Yajna Sri -> Simuka -> Satakarni I -> Gautamiputra.
- B. Gautamiputra -> Naganika/Satakarni I -> Simuka -> Pulumavi.
- C. Rudradaman -> Nahapana -> Simuka -> Yajna Sri.
- D. Simuka -> Satakarni I/Naganika -> Gautamiputra -> Vashishthiputra Pulumavi -> Yajna Sri.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the conventional founder cannot follow the later Yajna Sri. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the early Naneghat generation precedes Gautamiputra. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: this mixes rival Kshatrapas with Satavahana rulers in the wrong order. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: the sequence is exam-safe as a broad order, while absolute dates and some intermediate rulers remain disputed. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: Sequence questions test relative order; do not smuggle disputed exact dates into otherwise secure ruler ordering.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims 2026, Set A, Q13: Amaravati

Verification status: Official question wording checked against the locally held Set-A paper. The key used here is the locally held provisional key and is labelled accordingly.

Question: Which statements on the Amaravati Stupa and its relief sculpture are correct? (1) It was located in the lower Krishna valley. (2) In India, it was next only to the Sanchi Stupa in size. (3) The Amaravati school made a lasting impact on later South Indian sculpture, and its products were carried to Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia.

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Key: C - provisional key, not represented as a final UPSC-issued key.

Solved route: Statement 1 is correct because Amaravati-Dharanikota belongs to the lower Krishna valley. Statement 2 is rejected by the provisional key's framing. Statement 3 is accepted as an art-circulation claim. The final limit is essential: artistic transmission does not prove Satavahana political rule in Sri Lanka or Southeast Asia.

Verified PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims 2023, Q41: Dhanyakataka

Verification status: Official question wording checked locally; an official key was not available in the repository. The answer is therefore explicitly inferred.

Question: In which region was Dhanyakataka, which flourished as a prominent Buddhist centre under the Mahasanghikas, located?

- A. Andhra
- B. Gandhara
- C. Kalinga
- D. Magadha

Key: A - inferred, high confidence; not officially verified.

Solved route: Dhanyakataka/Dharanikota belongs to the lower Krishna-Andhra Buddhist landscape associated with Amaravati. Gandhara is north-western, Kalinga is centred farther north-east, and Magadha belongs to the middle Gangetic region.

Verified PYQ 3 - UPSC GS-I Mains 2020, Q1: rock-cut architecture

Verification status: Official printed Mains question checked against the locally held UPSC paper. UPSC does not issue a model answer; the response below is independently authored.

Question: The rock-cut architecture represents one of the most important sources of our knowledge of early Indian art and history. Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model route: Define caves as architectural, epigraphic and social archives. Use Barabar for early royal-Ajivika patronage; Bhaja and Karla/Karle for chaitya-vihara form and route society; Nashik for rival Kshatrapa-Satavahana inscriptions, grants and donors; Kanheri for a long western monastic network. Conclude that durable monuments reveal technology, patronage and institutions, but privilege resource-holding donors and require phase-specific dating.

Verified PYQ 4 - UPSC Prelims 2023, Q42: stupa origin and function

Verification status: Official question wording checked locally; official key unavailable locally, so the answer is explicitly inferred.

Question: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. All three
- D. None

Key: B - inferred, high confidence; not officially verified.

Solved route: Statement 1 is incorrect because funerary mound traditions were not exclusively Buddhist in origin. Statements 2 and 3 correctly describe major Buddhist functions. Amaravati's mahachaitya was also a changing ritual, artistic and donative complex, not merely a relic container.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL ANSWERS

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks

Question: Assess the historical value of Gautamiputra Satakarni's overstrikes on Nahapana's coins. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (144 words):

Gautamiputra's overstrikes are unusually strong evidence for a political reversal in the western Deccan, but they are not a complete territorial map. The Jogalthembi hoard contained a large body of Nahapana's silver coins, many carrying new Satavahana devices and legends. Reusing the established silver stock joined monetary continuity with a visible claim of authority. Gautami Balashri's Nashik prashasti calls Gautamiputra the destroyer of the Kshaharatas, while grant evidence indicates transfer of fiscal control from circles associated with Nahapana's son-in-law Ushavadata. The convergence of coin, inscription and grant therefore supports displacement of Kshaharata power more securely than any source alone. Yet overstriking cannot fix one battle date, the duration of restored rule or every frontier. It may also reflect metal economy and the convenience of revalidating familiar currency. The evidence is decisive for takeover and currency appropriation, but regional and chronological claims must remain bounded.

Word-count control: 144/150; independently isolated and countable.

Examiner method: Claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification. The answer directly obeys the directive and closes with a graded verdict.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks

Question: What do Satavahana matronymics and inscriptions reveal about royal women? (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (142 words):

Satavahana evidence gives royal women exceptional genealogical and donative visibility, but it does not establish matriarchy. Names such as Gautamiputra and Vashishthiputra associate kings with the mother's gotra or lineage, making maternal affiliation useful in a polygynous and alliance-based court. Naganika's Naneghat inscription records genealogy, major Vedic sacrifices and gifts, showing a queen shaping public dynastic legitimacy. Gautami Balashri's Nashik prashasti became the authoritative memorial of her son Gautamiputra's victories and social claims. Inscriptions also preserve women donors beyond the palace, revealing participation in Buddhist institutions and route society. However, the succession remained predominantly male and patrilineal, while the donor record favours women with resources and public access. Matronymics therefore indicate the political value of maternal lineage and the agency of royal women within a patriarchal order; they do not prove female-line succession, female ownership of the state or a matriarchal constitution.

Word-count control: 142/150; independently isolated and countable.

Examiner method: Claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification. The answer directly obeys the directive and closes with a graded verdict.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks

Question: Why is the Satavahana state better described as a layered network polity than as a uniformly centralized empire? (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (213 words):

The Satavahanas exercised substantial military, fiscal and ideological power, yet their realm was integrated through graded authority rather than one uniform bureaucracy. Aharas and officers such as amatyas, mahamatras and mahasenapatis show royal administration: the crown could divide territory, issue grants, mobilize resources and maintain records. But the precise reach of these offices varied, and shared terminology does not reproduce the Mauryan state.

Maharathis and mahabhojas appear as regional chiefs, donors and marriage partners. Their visibility shows that the dynasty incorporated established lineages instead of replacing them everywhere. Village intermediaries, merchants, shrenis, Buddhist establishments and Brahmanical beneficiaries connected local production and social authority with the court. Naneghat converted a strategic pass into royal ritual display; Nashik records successive Kshatrapa and Satavahana claims; coin distributions and overstrikes show shifting rather than permanent control. Pratishthana was a major western centre, while eastern coin and inscription zones became prominent under later rulers, making a single fixed-capital model unsafe.

Thus 'network polity' does not mean weakness or statelessness. It explains how strong kingship operated across unequal regions through officials, chiefs, routes and institutions. The qualification is equally important: titles such as 'lord of the Dakshinapatha' and prashasti geographies express aspiration as well as achieved power. Satavahana sovereignty was durable and expansive, but negotiated, multi-centred and regionally uneven.

Word-count control: 213/250; independently isolated and countable.

Examiner method: Claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification. The answer directly obeys the directive and closes with a graded verdict.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks

Question: Analyse the agrarian, craft and commercial bases of Satavahana power without overstating Roman trade. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (217 words):

Satavahana power rested on the interaction of rural production, craft specialization and connected markets, not on Roman trade alone. In suitable Krishna-Godavari zones, paddy transplantation and water management supported intensified agriculture; cotton and other crops linked cultivators with textile production. Iron tools, wells, tanks and expanding settlements widened production unevenly across the plateau. Early grants and fiscal immunities transferred revenue rights to Brahmanas or religious establishments, but their limited and varied clauses should not be equated automatically with a mature feudal order.

Excavated Deccan centres reveal ironworking, beads, pottery, textiles and other crafts. Shrenis and occupational donors could organize production, identity and endowments; deposits whose interest supported monasteries show finance embedded in institutions. Inland centres such as Pratishthana and Tagara connected through passes, especially Naneghat, with western ports, while eastern routes reached the lower Krishna.

Roman and Mediterranean objects, coins and trade-text references demonstrate participation in long-distance exchange. They do not prove Roman political control, universal monetization or prosperity across every village. Satavahana coinage itself used lead, potin and copper, with some silver and regionally varied symbols; Yajna Sri's ship motifs indicate maritime orientation, not a quantified navy. Therefore the economy was a multi-scalar system in which agrarian surplus, crafts, inland exchange and Indian Ocean contact reinforced one another, with gains distributed unevenly across regions and groups.

Word-count control: 217/250; independently isolated and countable.

Examiner method: Claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification. The answer directly obeys the directive and closes with a graded verdict.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks

Question: How do inscriptions, coins, archaeology and literary traditions together reconstruct Satavahana history, and where do they leave uncertainty? (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (221 words):

Satavahana history is strongest where independent archives converge and weakest where one source is forced beyond its capacity. Puranic lists preserve Andhra and Andhra-Bhritya dynastic memory, but recensions differ in ruler totals, duration and sequence; they cannot settle homeland or ethnicity. The Naneghat inscription supplies early genealogy, Naganika's ritual programme and a route-side statement of kingship. Nashik inscriptions anchor Gautamiputra, Gautami Balashri, Pulumavi, grants and rival Kshatrapa phases. Yet damaged labels and prashasti rhetoric prevent a complete neutral chronology.

Coins identify rulers omitted or confused in texts, reveal metals and symbols, and show regional circulation. The Jogalthembi overstrikes on Nahapana provide material corroboration of Gautamiputra's takeover. Nevertheless, a findspot is not automatically a capital or border. Archaeology at settlements, caves and Amaravati reveals crafts, water facilities, donors, urban nodes and long religious sequences; material culture, however, cannot be assigned to a dynasty without secure context.

The Gatha Saptashati tradition, Puranas, the Periplus and classical notices illuminate social memory and trade, but genre, redaction and outsider categories limit literal use. The safest reconstruction therefore uses broad chronological ranges, phase-specific political maps and a claim-evidence-limit method. Simuka remains a conventional founder; Pratishthana is a major western centre; Amaravati-Dharanikota is a major eastern religious-political zone, not a timeless capital certainty. Triangulation yields a persuasive regional history while preserving unresolved dates, lineages and territorial depth.

Word-count control: 221/250; independently isolated and countable.

Examiner method: Claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification. The answer directly obeys the directive and closes with a graded verdict.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks

Question: Discuss Satavahana social and religious formation through varna claims, occupational donors and plural patronage. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (217 words):

Satavahana society combined royal claims to hierarchy with evidence of occupational mobility, cultural assimilation and plural religious patronage. Gautamiputra's Nashik eulogy presents him as a unique Brahmana and defender of varna order. This was a language of legitimacy, not a demographic census: inscriptions simultaneously name merchants, artisans, perfumers, metalworkers, cultivators, Yavana donors, monks, nuns and women patrons. Such records reveal public identity and surplus among visible donors, although they underrepresent people unable to endow durable monuments.

Matronymics such as Gautamiputra and Vashishthiputra highlight maternal gotra and alliance without proving matriarchy. Naganika's Naneghat record and Gautami Balashri's Nashik prashasti show royal women shaping genealogy, sacrifice and dynastic memory within a predominantly patrilineal order. Persons of foreign association adopted regional names, languages and donative practices, indicating selective assimilation rather than either permanent isolation or instant cultural disappearance.

Religious evidence is similarly plural. Naneghat records major Brahmanical sacrifices and royal gifts, while Nashik, Karla/Karle, Kanheri and other cave complexes received support from rulers, Kshatrapas, merchants, artisans, women and local elites. Amaravati's long Buddhist sequence belongs to a wider lower Krishna donor network and continued beyond Satavahana rule. Patronage could produce merit, legitimacy and route-based alliances; it does not prove an exclusive state religion or private conversion. Satavahana formation was therefore hierarchical but socially negotiated, Brahmanically articulated yet institutionally plural.

Word-count control: 217/250; independently isolated and countable.

Examiner method: Claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification. The answer directly obeys the directive and closes with a graded verdict.